

Option 30: Russia and the Soviet Union, 1917–41

Key topic 1: The revolutions of 1917

1 The growth of opposition to the tsar in early 1917	• Growing discontent among peasants and town workers. • The impact of the First World War: military defeats; economic, political and social effects; the Tsar as commander-in-chief.
2 The February Revolution	• The immediate reasons for the February Revolution: events in Petrograd in February 1917, including strikes and the mutiny in the army. The Tsar's absence and abdication.
3 The Provisional Government	• The establishment of the Provisional Government and the problems it faced, including 'Dual Control' and Soviet Order Number 1. The role of Kerensky. • The weaknesses and failures of the Provisional Government. • The significance of the Kornilov Revolt.
4 The Bolshevik Revolution	• Lenin's return and activities, including the April Theses and the growth in support for the Bolshevik Party. The 'July Days'. • The Bolshevik seizure of power in October 1917. The reasons for their success. The roles of Trotsky and Lenin.

Key topic 2: The Bolsheviks in power, 1917–24

1 Early consolidation of power, 1917–18	• The early Bolshevik decrees of November–December 1917. • The removal of opposition, including the Constituent Assembly and the execution of Tsar Nicholas II and his family. • The reasons for, main terms, and significance of, the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk. Different reactions in Russia to the Treaty.
2 The Civil War, 1918–21	• The reasons for, key events and effects of the Civil War. • The reasons for the Bolshevik victory, including the strengths of the Bolsheviks, role of Trotsky, foreign intervention and the weaknesses of the Whites.
3 Moves towards totalitarianism	• The Red Terror and the role of the Cheka. The Kronstadt Mutiny. • Bolshevik centralisation, including the role of Lenin and the Politburo. Setting up of the USSR.
4 Economic and social change, 1918–24	• Reasons for, and features of, War Communism. Reasons for its unpopularity. • Reasons for, and features of, the New Economic Policy. Different reactions to the NEP. Its effects on the economy, 1921–24. • Social changes, including the impact of Bolshevik policies on women, education and culture.

Key topic 3: Stalin's rise to power and dictatorship, 1924–41

1 The struggle for power, 1924–28	• The strengths and weaknesses of Stalin and his rivals (Trotsky, Kamenev, Zinoviev and Bukharin). • The reasons for the emergence of Stalin as leader of the USSR, including the removal of rivals for the leadership in the years 1924–28.
2 The use of terror in the 1930s	• The reasons for, nature of and consequences of the purges, including the purges of the armed forces. • The work of the secret police (NKVD); the use of, and conditions in, the labour camps. • The reasons for, and the importance of, the show trials of 1936–1938.
3 Propaganda and censorship	• Official culture, socialist realism, control of education and religion. Media censorship. • The new Constitution of 1936.
4 The Cult of Stalin	• The meaning of the Cult of Stalin and reasons for its introduction. • How the Cult of Stalin was achieved.

Key topic 4: Economic and social changes, 1924–41

1 Agriculture and collectivisation	• Stalin's reasons for changes in agriculture, including the problems of the NEP. • The organisation of collectives, mechanisation, widespread opposition and the attack on the kulaks. Famine in Ukraine. • The successes and failures of collectivisation.
2 Changes in industry	• Stalin's motives for rapid industrialisation, including the failings of the NEP. • Gosplan, Five-Year Plans and the Stakhanovite Movement. • The successes and failures of industrialisation.
3 Life in the Soviet Union	• Living and working conditions in towns and the countryside. • The differing experiences of social groups.
4 The position of women and ethnic minorities	• Changes in family life and employment and the political position of women. • Reasons for, and features of, the persecution of ethnic minorities.